Beg, or, now, between Sayyid Musa and the beguiling Mohini.

Some five years before Akbar began his debates in the Ibadat Khana, at about the time that Akbar's Rajput queen was pregnant with Salim, a young sayyid nobleman from Kalpi called Musa arrived in Agra to pay his respects to the increasingly powerful padishah. Musa was making his way through the city when he caught a glimpse of a beautiful face at a high window. It was Mohini he had seen; she was a goldsmith's wife, and he was ensnared in 'the lasso of her pure glance'.

Fortunately for his heart, less so for his future, Musa's feelings were returned. The lovers knew they were treading dangerous ground and so, for two and a half years, they were 'content with a glance now and then from afar'. But patience is not the strong suit of wildly beating hearts. One night, Musa took his life in his hands and broke into Mohini's house, climbing up to her room 'like a rope-dancer' and finding his own home in her arms.

The next morning, Mohini left home with her lover, 'despising fair fame and reputation', writes Badauni with admiration, '. . . as the moonlight with the moon'. Soon, however, as her relatives gathered in protest and Musa's life came under threat, Mohini returned home. She told her family that she had been spirited away to an enchanted land. 'The silly Hindus believed this beautiful deception,' says Badauni, though evidently not without large grains of salt, for they kept Mohini 'in a ring of iron serpents' from now on, shut away 'in an upper room' under lock and key.

In the time-honoured manner of lovers separated from their beloveds, Musa went mad. Mohini, unable to bear the thought of her suitor's grief, escaped once again – and once again, the lovers were caught and parted. This time, the police was involved, and Musa was sent to jail where, from longing, he grew as 'thin as a new moon'.

Again – a third time – the lovers tried. A man called Qazi Jamal, a Hindi poet possessed of a good horse and strong nerves, helped them. He carried Mohini away on his 'charger, head-tossing like the . . . steed of Fate . . . wind-footed and prancing', racing along the banks of the Yamuna with half of Agra watching.

Mohini's relatives were chasing behind, and many of Agra's citizens 'who were spectators of the scene [were shouting] in front' – and yet, the young girl might have made her escape if the steed of fate had not caught its feet in the mud. Mohini threw herself off the horse and told the poet to escape –